
the
MARRIAGE
Reset

A 30 DAYS GUIDE FOR
COUPLES DRIFTING APART



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The path back

Thirty days. Four weeks. One practice at a time.

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The Marriage Reset is an educational workbook. It is not therapy, counseling, or medical advice, and it is not a substitute for professional help. Results vary from couple to couple. If you are in crisis or danger, contact local emergency services.

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WELCOME

You became roommates.

You still love each other. The conversations got shorter. The silences got longer. You did not fall out of love. You drifted. The gap is not love lost. It is practice lost.

Most couples do not lose each other because they stopped caring. They lose each other because they stopped practicing the small things that kept them close: noticing each other, speaking honestly, following through on small promises. That is a smaller problem to solve than it feels like from inside it.

What the next 30 days actually are

This is a structured daily reset – not a crisis intervention, and not a program for recovering from an affair. If that is what you are facing, see a licensed counselor first. This workbook is not built for that weight. If you are already in counseling, this sits alongside that work, or as a first small step before it – not instead of it.

Each day takes about ten minutes. Most weeks include two short *Couple* sessions; everything else is solo. If your spouse is not ready to open a workbook yet, you can still start tonight.

Faith is an invitation, never a requirement. Skip any prayer line. The practical work stands on its own.

Please read this

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The rhythm

Week 1 - Notice. See where the distance shows up. **Week 2 - Speak.** Reopen the conversation, safely. **Week 3 - Trust.** Rebuild it in small actions. **Week 4 - Reconnect.** Choose each other again, out loud.

Tonight, before Day 1

Sit down together for five minutes (or alone) with the Weekly Check-In Card:

1. How are we, really?
2. What do we need right now?
3. What is one small next step?

Write the answers where you will find them again. You will compare them on Day 30. That is tonight's whole task.



WEEK 1 • NOTICE

Notice

This week is observation – where the distance shows up, and what you are quietly longing for underneath it.

COUPLE OR SOLO

DAY 1 • QUICK WIN

Name the Distance

If you did the Check-In Card last night, you have already started. If not, do it now – five minutes, and today counts as a win.

Why this matters

Naming a feeling out loud, even just on paper, changes it. "We're drifting" stops being a vague dread and starts being something you can work on, one Tuesday at a time.

Today's reflection

- Read back what you wrote on the Check-In Card. Does anything surprise you?
- Without blaming anyone, finish this sentence:

Lately, our marriage has felt more like

than a partnership.

If you are starting this alone: answer both questions for yourself. Noticing is never something you can get wrong.

If it helps: a short prayer of thanks for even this small first step is a good way to close today.

Where the Roommates Began

Roommate distance rarely arrives all at once. It builds from a hundred small trades – a real conversation swapped for a logistics update, again and again, until logistics is most of what is left.

Why this matters

You cannot undo years of drift in a day, but you can start noticing the exact moment connection gets swapped for scheduling. That is the moment worth protecting next time.

Today's reflection

Think of one conversation from this past week. Was it about connection, or was it about logistics – schedules, bills, who is picking up the kids?

If it was logistics, what might a two-minute version of that same conversation have looked like with one extra, personal sentence added?

If you are starting this alone: you are only tracking your own side of these conversations today. That is enough data to work with.

The Bid You Almost Missed

Researchers who have spent decades watching how couples actually interact found something surprisingly small mattered most: how partners respond to tiny, everyday bids for attention. A sigh. A comment about the weather. A "hey, look at this." The couples who stayed close were not the ones with no problems. They were the ones who noticed these small bids and turned toward them, again and again.

Why this matters

You do not need a grand romantic gesture this week. You need to catch one small bid you would otherwise miss.

Today's reflection

Recall a moment recently when your spouse said something small – a comment, a question, a sigh – and you were distracted, tired, or elsewhere.

I think I missed a bid when

If you are starting this alone: this is about your own noticing, not your spouse's behavior. You are building the muscle, not scoring anyone.

What Am I Actually Longing For?

Under almost every complaint about a marriage is a softer, more vulnerable longing that rarely gets said out loud. "You never listen" is often really "I want to feel important to you." "We never do anything" is often really "I miss feeling chosen."

Why this matters

You cannot ask for what you have not named, even to yourself.

Today's reflection

Set the complaints aside for a moment. Underneath the frustration, what are you actually longing for – closeness? Being known? Feeling chosen? Partnership?

What I am really longing for is

If you are starting this alone: keep this one private for now if you need to. You will have a safe, structured way to share it in Week 2.

The Story I Have Been Telling Myself

Every drifting marriage comes with a private narrative running underneath it – "we are just not compatible anymore," "this is just what marriage becomes," "it is too late to fix this." These stories feel like facts. Usually, they are just the loudest interpretation available at 11 p.m. on a hard day.

Why this matters

The story you tell yourself about your marriage shapes what you are willing to try. A slightly gentler, equally true story opens up more options than a hopeless one does.

Today's reflection

Write the private story you have been telling yourself – one or two sentences, no editing.

Now write one alternative story that is just as true but gentler. (Example: "We are just not compatible" becomes "We used to know how to reach each other, and we can learn that again.")

If you are starting this alone: this exercise works the same either way – you are examining your own story, not predicting your spouse's.

A Small Turn Toward

Today is about doing something with everything you have noticed this week – one small, concrete turn toward each other.

Why this matters

You do not need a resolved conversation to start turning toward each other again. You need one small, repeatable moment of attention.

Today's session (10 minutes together)

- Each of you name one specific bid you will try to notice and respond to this week – a tone of voice, a certain sigh, a particular kind of question.
- Agree on a simple signal for "I need you to turn toward me right now" that either of you can use, even mid-argument.

The bid I will watch for

Our signal

If you are going through this alone: choose your own bid to watch for in your spouse this week, without announcing it. You are practicing the noticing either way – sharing the agreement is a bonus, not a requirement.

What Notice Week Showed Us

One week of noticing is behind you. Today is for taking stock – gently, without turning it into a performance review.

Why this matters

Naming what you noticed, out loud, to each other, is itself a small act of reconnection – often the first real one in a while.

Today's session (10–15 minutes together)

- Each share one thing you noticed this week about the distance, and one thing you noticed you were longing for. Listen without fixing or defending.
- Complete the Weekly Check-In Card again. Compare it, gently, to Day 1's answers – not to judge progress, just to see it.

One thing I noticed

One thing I was longing for

If you are going through this alone: write both answers for yourself, and consider sharing just one of them with your spouse this week, low-pressure, whenever it feels natural.

If it helps: close the week with a short prayer of thanks for what you were willing to see, even in its early, unfinished shape.

End of Week 1. Next: Week 2 – Speak, where noticing turns into a safe way to reopen the harder conversations.



WEEK 2 • SPEAK

Speak

What you are missing is not motivation. It is the actual words for the moment things get tense.

SOLO

DAY 8

Why Words Got Hard

Most couples do not stop talking because they ran out of things to say. They stop because talking started to feel risky – like it might turn into a fight, or into silence that is somehow worse than a fight.

Why this matters

Under stress, most people default to one of two patterns – pushing to resolve things right now, or going quiet until it blows over. Neither is wrong. Both make sense as protection. Naming your own pattern is the first step to choosing something else when it counts.

Today's reflection

Under stress, do you tend to push to talk it out immediately, or go quiet and pull back? Neither answer is a character flaw – just notice which is yours.

What does your spouse tend to do? (If you are not sure, that is useful information too.)

If you are going through this alone: you can only be sure of your own pattern today, and that is exactly enough to work with this week.

Reacting vs. Repairing

Every couple argues. What separates the ones who stay close from the ones who drift apart is not the absence of conflict – it is what happens in the middle of it. A repair attempt is any small thing, said or done, that puts the brakes on before things spiral: a joke, an apology, a hand on the arm, a simple "can we slow down."

Why this matters

You have probably already made repair attempts without having a name for them. Recognizing them makes you more likely to use them on purpose.

Today's reflection

Think of a recent disagreement. Was there a moment either of you tried to de-escalate – a joke, an apology, a pause? What happened when they did?

If no repair attempt was made, what might one have sounded like?

If you are going through this alone: you are building awareness you will use starting tomorrow, whether or not your spouse is doing this exercise alongside you.

Naming What Is Underneath

Most complaints are a smaller, sharper version of a bigger, softer feeling. "You're always on your phone" is often really "I feel invisible when we are in the same room." The complaint gets said. The feeling underneath rarely does.

Why this matters

The sharp version tends to start a fight. The soft version tends to start a real conversation.

Today's reflection

Write down one complaint you have had recently – the sharp, surface version, exactly as it would come out in the moment.

Now rewrite it, naming the softer feeling underneath:

When

happens, I feel

If you are going through this alone: keep both versions somewhere you can find them. Tomorrow's tool is where you will learn when and how to actually say the second one.

The Communication Repair Script

You do not need to be naturally good at hard conversations. You need six lines, ready before you need them – the same way you would keep a fire extinguisher somewhere you can reach it without thinking.

Say the line out loud, exactly as written. The formality is the point. A scripted line signals "I am trying to de-escalate" more clearly than an improvised one.

1. **"Can we start over?"** – the moment you hear your own voice sharpen.
2. **"I think I said that wrong – let me try again."** – right after you notice you were harsher than you meant to be.
3. **"I'm not trying to win this. I'm trying to understand you."** – when it starts feeling like a debate.
4. **"Can you say more about what that felt like for you?"** – when your partner is vulnerable and you want to defend.
5. **"I need five minutes before I can talk about this calmly."** – name a time, then actually return.
6. **"You're more important to me than being right about this."** – when the topic is small and the tension is not.

Two prompts that make honesty feel safer

- "What's one thing that would help you feel safe telling me the truth right now?"
- "If I promise not to react right away, is there something you've been wanting to say?"

Every one of these six lines works even if your spouse has never seen this book. Today's reflection: which line is hardest to imagine saying out loud? That is usually the one worth practicing first.

The line I will practice first

Practicing the Script

A script only works if it is already familiar the first time you need it under pressure. Today is for trying one line on purpose, in a low-stakes moment, so it is not brand new the first time it actually matters.

Today's session (10 minutes together)

- Pick one small, real friction from the past week or so – nothing catastrophic, just something mildly annoying.
- Practice bringing it up using one line from yesterday's script. Notice how it changes the shape of the conversation, even artificially.
- Afterward, each share which line felt most natural to say, and which felt stiff or awkward.

The friction we chose

The line we used

What we noticed

If you are going through this alone: practice saying one line out loud to yourself, or use it for real the next time a small friction comes up – even without announcing that you are "doing an exercise." The line works the same either way.

When Honesty Feels Risky

Somewhere in every drifting marriage is at least one honest thing that has not been said – not because it is shameful, but because saying it feels like it might change something, and change feels risky when you are already unsteady.

Why this matters

The things left unsaid do not disappear. They just sit underneath everything else, quietly making every other conversation a little more guarded.

Today's reflection

Is there something you have been holding back – not a confession, just an honest thought or feeling you have not voiced? Name it for yourself, even if you are not ready to say it aloud yet.

What is the actual fear underneath not saying it? Being misunderstood? Starting a fight? Being seen as needy or difficult?

If you are going through this alone: you do not have to share this today, or even this month. Naming it privately is real progress on its own, and the script will be here whenever you are ready to use it.

If it helps: a short prayer for courage to be honest – not for the perfect words, just the willingness – is a quiet way to close today.

Speak Week Recap

A week of learning to speak differently is behind you. Today is for taking stock of what is actually working, not grading yourselves on how well you have "done" it.

Today's session (10-15 minutes together)

- Revisit the six script lines together. Which ones do you both want to keep using on purpose going forward?
- Complete the Weekly Check-In Card again. Notice anything different from Day 7's answers – even something small.

Lines we want to keep

Something that felt different this week

If you are going through this alone: choose your own one or two lines to keep carrying forward, and consider using one of them for real this week, even without narrating the exercise behind it.

End of Week 2. Next: Week 3 – Trust, where honest conversations turn into small, repeatable actions that make safety feel real again.



WEEK 3 • TRUST

Trust

Trust comes back the same way it left – in small moments, repeated until they are reflexive.

SOLO

DAY 15

Trust Is Built in Seconds, Not Speeches

If you ask most long-married couples what keeps them close, they rarely point to a grand vacation or a big speech. They point to small things they do without fail – a particular greeting, a nightly check-in, a habit so ordinary it barely looks like effort from the outside.

Why this matters

You are not looking for a dramatic fix this week. You are looking for one small, protected moment you can actually keep.

Today's reflection

Did you and your spouse used to have a small ritual – a greeting, a routine, a habit – that has quietly disappeared? What was it?

What made it easy to keep, back when you kept it?

If you are going through this alone: you can start a ritual on your own side this week – greeting your spouse a certain way, asking a particular question – without needing their buy-in first. Small, one-sided consistency is still real trust-building.

If it helps: a short prayer of thanks for the ordinary, unremarkable moments of a marriage is a good way to close today.

Pick One Ritual

You will get a full menu on Day 19. Today is just for narrowing your thinking, so you are not choosing on the spot later.

Why this matters

A ritual only works if it is small enough to actually keep. Ambitious plans get abandoned by week two. Tiny ones survive.

Today's reflection

Of these three starting points, which feels most doable for you this week, not someday?

- ☐ A real greeting at reunion
- ☐ A genuine "how was your day"
- ☐ A moment of gratitude before sleep

What has gotten in the way of a habit like this sticking before?

If you are going through this alone: choose a ritual you can start on your own end regardless of participation – a warmer greeting, a genuine question – and let it be a gift with no immediate return expected.

The Kept Promise

Trust is not really about big declarations. It is built – or worn down – in small promises: "I'll call you at lunch," "I'll take care of it," "I won't forget." Kept or missed, these add up faster than almost anything else in a marriage.

Why this matters

You do not need to fix every broken promise from the past. You need to start noticing the small ones you are keeping and missing right now.

Today's reflection

Think of one small promise – yours or your spouse's – that was kept this week. How did it land, even if it seemed minor?

Think of one that was missed. Try to notice this without building a case against anyone – just observe it.

If you are going through this alone: focus today on the promises you are keeping. That is the half of this you have full control over.

Trust as a Daily Deposit

Think of trust like a shared account. Every small positive moment – a kind word, a kept promise, a moment of real attention – is a deposit. Every dismissal or broken promise is a withdrawal. Neither one is dramatic on its own. The balance is what matters over time.

Why this matters

You do not need one huge deposit to feel safer together. You need more small deposits than withdrawals, most weeks.

Today's reflection

What is one small deposit you made into your marriage this week – something easy to overlook, but real?

What is one small deposit your spouse made, that you might not have acknowledged out loud?

If you are going through this alone: notice your own deposits this week without needing them matched right away. Consistency, not immediate reciprocity, is what rebuilds trust.

If it helps: name one thing you are grateful your spouse has deposited into this marriage over the years, even during the drift – and consider telling them, plainly, sometime this week.

The Trust Micro-Habits Menu

Pick one. Not all of these – one. Keep it for at least a week before you consider adding another. Small and kept beats ambitious and abandoned, every time.

- ☐ **The six-second kiss.** A real one, not a peck, at a transition point – leaving or coming home.
- ☐ **The welcome-home routine.** The first two minutes after reunion are phone-down, full attention.
- ☐ **The daily map question.** Ask, "what's one thing you're looking forward to – or dreading – today?"
- ☐ **The stress-reducing ten.** Ten minutes each day just listening to outside-world stress. No fixing.
- ☐ **One spoken appreciation.** Name one specific thing your partner did, out loud, every day.
- ☐ **The kept-promise note.** Tell your partner the moment you follow through on something small.
- ☐ **Tech-free dinner.** Phones away for one meal a day, even if it is only fifteen minutes.
- ☐ **Bedtime gratitude.** One sentence each, last thing before sleep: "today I was grateful for..."

The one I will try first, and why

If you are going through this alone: several of these work as one-sided gifts – the spoken appreciation, the kept-promise note, a genuine welcome-home moment. Start there. Tell your spouse which one, if you are doing this together – or simply start it quietly this week.

Practicing the Ritual

You picked a ritual yesterday. Today is for actually doing it – not planning it, not discussing it further, just doing it once, on purpose.

Today's session

- Do the ritual you chose, today, together.
- Afterward, take two minutes to notice out loud: did it feel awkward, natural, too small to matter, surprisingly nice? There is no right answer – you are just building the habit of noticing.

The ritual we did

How it felt

If you are going through this alone: do your chosen ritual on your own side today, without announcing it as an exercise. Notice how it felt to you, and whether it changed anything about the moment, even slightly.

Trust Week Recap

A week of small, repeated actions is behind you. Today's task is simple: notice what is actually sticking, and decide – plainly – to keep it going.

Today's session (10-15 minutes together)

- Is the ritual you chose still happening, three or four days in? If it is already slipping, that is useful information, not failure – pick a smaller version and try again.
- Complete the Weekly Check-In Card again. Compare it gently to Day 14's answers.

What is sticking

The smaller version, if we need one

If you are going through this alone: decide, plainly, whether to keep your chosen ritual going into next week regardless of any visible change from your spouse. Consistency on your end is still the work.

If it helps: close the week with a short prayer of thanks for whatever small trust has started to return – even something too small to mention out loud yet.

End of Week 3. Next: Week 4 – Reconnect, ending with the Day 30 Recommitment Ceremony.



WEEK 4 • RECONNECT

Reconnect

Name what is actually different. Then choose, out loud, to keep going.

SOLO

DAY 22

What Is Different Now

Three Check-In Cards are behind you, filled out honestly, in the middle of ordinary weeks. Today is for reading them side by side.

Why this matters

Change over 21 days is almost always smaller and quieter than you would want it to be – and easy to miss unless you actually go back and look.

Today's reflection

Read your Day 1, Day 7, Day 14, and Day 21 Check-In Cards in order. What is one real shift, even a small one?

What has not changed yet – and is that okay for now?

If you are going through this alone: your own answers are the whole comparison today. Change on one side of a marriage still counts as real change.

The Both/And

Here is something worth saying plainly: this workbook does not end with a fixed marriage. It ends with a marriage that has better tools than it had 30 days ago. Those are different things, and only one of them is realistic.

Why this matters

Expecting a finished, permanent fix sets you up to feel like a failure the first time an old pattern resurfaces. Expecting ongoing practice sets you up to keep going when that happens.

Today's reflection

What is one old pattern you expect might resurface sometime after Day 30?

What is one tool from these 30 days you would reach for, specifically, when it does?

If you are going through this alone: the same both/and applies to solo effort. You are not expecting to single-handedly fix a marriage in a month – you are building tools you will keep using regardless of pace.

A Letter Begins

You will exchange something like this on Day 30. Today is just for starting the draft, honestly, with no pressure to get it right the first time. Use Bonus 2 – the Recommitment Letter Template – if you want more room.

Why this matters

Writing something down, in your own words, forces a kind of honesty that talking often lets you avoid.

What I have noticed about "us" over these 30 days

One thing I appreciate in my spouse that I do not say often enough

What I am choosing, starting today

If you are going through this alone: write this letter anyway. Keep it for whenever your spouse is ready to read it – or simply for yourself, as a record of what you were willing to choose, even alone.

What This Has Shaped in You

Thirty days of practical tools tends to leave a mark beyond the marriage itself – most people come out the other side a little more patient, a little more honest, a little better at loving someone imperfectly. Today's reflection stands on its own, faith or no faith.

Why this matters

Noticing how this process has shaped *you*, not just the marriage, is worth naming before the month ends.

Today's reflection

Where have you seen this marriage shape you – not just make you happy, but make you more patient, more honest, more able to love someone imperfectly?

If it is part of your life: a short, simple prayer for the next season – not for a perfect marriage, just for the willingness to keep choosing each other. If it is not your season for that, the question above is the whole day, and that is enough.

If you are going through this alone: both the reflection and the prayer work solo exactly as they do together.

The Final Approach

The days are getting shorter on purpose. You are close to Day 30 – these four are quick, one line each, meant to be answered in a minute or two rather than worked through slowly.

Day 26 – One word for this month. Just one.

Day 27 – One thing you are proud of, about how you showed up these 30 days.

Day 28 – One thing you are choosing to forgive – in your spouse, or in yourself.

Day 29 – One thing you are choosing, going into tomorrow.

If you are going through this alone: every one of these four questions is yours alone to answer, regardless of where your spouse is in the process.

The Recommitment Ceremony

This is not legally binding, and it does not need an officiant – just the two of you, ten quiet minutes, and the letters you started on Day 24. Find a moment without distraction. This does not need to be elaborate. It needs to be real.

Opening (read together, or one partner reads aloud)

Thirty days ago, we named something true: we hadn't fallen out of love. We'd drifted. Today, we're choosing to stop drifting.

Spoken commitments (each partner completes and reads aloud)

In the next season, I choose to notice

In the next season, I choose to speak _____, even when it's hard.

In the next season, I choose to protect our ritual of

I choose you again – not because these thirty days fixed everything, but because I want to keep choosing you.

Optional faith blessing: a short prayer of thanks for the last 30 days, and a request for continued grace – in your own words. Optional gesture: exchange the letters, light a candle, or hold hands in silence for one full minute.

If you are going through this alone: speak your own commitments aloud, even to an empty room, and keep the letter for when your spouse is ready. A ceremony of one is still a real, spoken choice.

Beyond Day 30

The reset ends here. The habit doesn't. Choose one thing – the Check-In Card, one script line, one ritual – and keep doing that one thing into month two. Write it down. That is the last task of these 30 days, and maybe the most important one.

The one thing I will keep
